

MOVING DOWN THE PYRAMID

Backed by niche venture capitalists and foundations, a new breed of entrepreneurs brings products and services to the poor, taking its social responsibility seriously

Global Easy Water Products

Promoter: **AMITABHA SADANGI, 47**

Business: **Low-cost drip irrigation**

Revenue target: **Rs 60 crore by 2010**

BORN IN a village in Orissa in a family that earned less than Rs 10 a day, Amitabha Sadangi, motivated by the poverty around him, developed income-generating programmes for the rural

poor. Armed with a postgraduate degree in labour and social welfare, Sadangi worked for International Development Enterprises India before going on to form Global Easy Water Products in 2004. His company manufactures low-cost drip irrigation products for small farmers. While the average spend for installing a drip irrigation system is Rs 1.25 lakh per hectare,

■ By Malini Bhupta

Boys and girls in Saurath, a sleepy hamlet in Bihar, no longer flock to the big cities in search of jobs, thanks to a rural BPO set up by Drishtee, a company engaged in developing networks for delivering services to the village community. The BPO, which is digitising the records of libraries and banks, seeks to use technology to change the way rural India lives and consumes. Rural consumers can now get quotes for their crops, buy mobile phones and access their land records

Sadangi's systems cost Rs 25,000. He has already sold drip irrigation systems to 1.5 lakh households across six states. Sadangi sources technology from NGOs and outsources manufacturing to local factories. He has also partnered with companies like Reliance, Himalayan Drug Company and Bajaj Hindustan. These give buy-back guarantees to farmers using drip irrigation.

"The drip irrigation systems available now are not suitable for small farms."

RAVI S SAHANI

